

Finally a Glimmer of Hope

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Is it light at the end of the tunnel or simply lights out? That's the big question still looming over the embattled Indo-US nuclear deal. In what appears to be a concession of sorts, the Left parties have reluctantly agreed to allow the Government to start discussions with the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) for what is known as India-specific safeguards. But it has come with a caveat—the Government can't go ahead and sign the agreement until the "outcome is presented to the co-ordination committee" as External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee delicately phrased it. For the Government going to IAEA is important since without such a safeguard agreement, it cannot proceed with the final steps to make the deal operational.

The way for such a step was cleared over the weekend after half a dozen meetings of the UPA-Left committee on the Indo-US nuclear agreement and heaps of papers explaining positions on both sides were exchanged. Although among the Left partners, RSP and Forward Bloc were opposed to the idea of allowing the Government to even speak with IAEA, the Communists—CPI(M) and CPI—had been convinced otherwise. General secretaries—Prakash Karat and A.B. Bardhan—had been briefed about the Government's plan over a lunch at Prime Minister Manmohan Singh's residence the week before last. The presence of Congress President Sonia Gandhi there was important for the restoration of confidence in UPA's relationship with the Left. Warring over the bilateral treaty had not only taken away the Government's complete attention but had also hurt its image at home and abroad. An honourable way out from the standoff was necessary and the Congress leaders sought help from Karat and Bardhan.

Both the sides were cautious while announcing the decision and took pains to explain their stands. While they



might be watching the Government as it talks to IAEA in Vienna, the Left leaders are not anxious about the text of the safeguards agreement because they appear to have told the Government that they will reject the IAEA document once it is brought back to the joint nuclear committee for its endorsement. Sources say the written word, therefore, is of little significance to the Left as it holds the power to veto the agreement. The Left hopes that the Government would then abandon the Indo-US agreement citing the lack of political consensus. From Mukherjee's statement, it appears that the Government interprets the position differently. That while it's obliged to show the text of the agreement to the co-or-

dination committee and make changes if needed, it could proceed with finalising it with IAEA after that.

Having got the committee's clearance, India's negotiators moved quickly on the job. On November 21, Atomic Energy Commission Chairman Anil Kakodkar met IAEA Director-General Mohamed ElBaradei in Vienna to formally begin working out the text of the agreement. The Indian delegation is believed to have communicated that while India would thrash out the text of the safeguards agreement, the formal signing can take place later. The India-specific safeguards agreement essentially means that IAEA, the international atomic watchdog, can stipulate certain safeguards for reactors that India puts